ABITUR ENGLISH · WRITING

How to write a discussion

Operator: discuss

> **WHAT DOES "DISCUSS" MEAN?**
> *"express a well-founded opinion on sth., considering arguments for both sides of an issue, backing up one's argumentation with evidence and examples"*

Structure – compulsory

Your **opinion** determines the order: first two arguments **against** it (stronger one first), then two **for** it (stronger one last).

> **MODEL TASK**
> *"Nobody has the right to not be offended."* – Salman Rushdie
>
> Taking this statement as a starting point, **discuss** whether students should have the right to opt out of reading disturbing fiction at school.

PART	WHAT TO DO	MODEL OUTLINE – my opinion: no right to opt out
Introduction 1 paragraph	Begin with the **starting point**: who / what, context, line number if from the text. Its message in your own words – **do not analyse it**. Lead to the question. **No arguments, no opinion yet.**	Rushdie: free speech means accepting that one may be offended → does this also apply to reading at school? → should students be allowed to opt out of disturbing novels?
① – Against my opinion stronger ●●●	**Thesis statement → development → example.**	Protects students' well-being → disturbing scenes can reopen painful experiences → e.g. a student who has experienced violence reads a violent novel.
② – Against my opinion weaker ●●○	**Thesis statement → development → example.**	Respects students' own beliefs and maturity → older students can judge which texts are compatible with their values → e.g. a student whose religious convictions conflict with explicit scenes.
③ + For my opinion weaker ●●○	Signal the turn: *However, …* **Thesis statement → development → example.**	Shared reading needs everyone → if students opt out, class discussions lose perspectives → e.g. a debate on *To Kill a Mockingbird* without the students who skipped it.
④ + For my opinion stronger ●●●	Your best argument comes last. **Thesis statement → development → example.**	Disturbing fiction helps students grow → they face difficult topics in a safe, guided setting → e.g. *The Hate U Give* builds empathy for victims of racism.
Conclusion 1 paragraph	State your opinion clearly (*I* only here). Weigh up both sides briefly. Good idea: come back to the starting point. **No new arguments.**	Protection matters, but growth through discomfort matters more → coming back to Rushdie's statement, I believe students should not have a general right to opt out.

Checklist

BEFORE YOU WRITE

- Read the **starting point**: what does it say about the question?
- Collect arguments for both sides and **rank** them.
- Decide on **your opinion** – it determines the order.
- Choose **exactly two** arguments per side.
- Find a **concrete example** for every argument – never invent statistics.

WHILE YOU WRITE

- **One argument = one paragraph.** Indent or skip a line at the start.
- Every paragraph: **thesis statement → development → example.**
- Formal style: no contractions, no colloquial language.
- Quotes: *"…" (l. 17), (ll. 17-18), (ll. 17, 23)*; references: *(cf. l. 17)*
- Text type given? Same structure **plus** its features.

Useful phrases

Introduction	Einleitung
The quotation "…" (l. 36) **suggests that** …	Das Zitat „…" (Z. 36) legt nahe, dass …
In his / her statement, … **claims that** …	In seiner / ihrer Aussage behauptet …, dass …
The cartoon shows / criticizes …	Der Cartoon zeigt / kritisiert …
Taking up this idea, one may ask whether …	Daran anknüpfend kann man fragen, ob …
This raises the question of whether …	Dies wirft die Frage auf, ob …
Arguments against your opinion	**Argumente gegen die eigene Meinung**
Supporters / Opponents of … argue that …	Befürworter / Gegner von … argumentieren, dass …
One major argument against … is that …	Ein wichtiges Argument gegen … ist, dass …
Admittedly, … / **It cannot be denied that** …	Zugegebenermaßen … / Es lässt sich nicht bestreiten, dass …
Another point that is often made is that …	Ein weiterer häufig genannter Punkt ist, dass …
Turning to your side	**Überleitung zur eigenen Seite**
However, there are also convincing reasons for …	Es gibt jedoch auch überzeugende Gründe für …
On the other hand, … / **Nevertheless**, …	Andererseits … / Dennoch …
Arguments for your opinion	**Argumente für die eigene Meinung**
Furthermore / **Moreover** / **What is more**, …	Darüber hinaus / Außerdem / Zudem …
Most importantly, … / **The most important argument is that** …	Am wichtigsten ist, dass … / Das wichtigste Argument ist, dass …
Above all, one must not forget that …	Vor allem darf man nicht vergessen, dass …
Contrast and concession	**Gegensatz und Einräumung**
It is true that …, but …	Zwar …, aber …
Although … / **Even though** …	Obwohl … / Auch wenn …
In spite of / **Despite** all these arguments, …	Trotz all dieser Argumente …
Giving examples and evidence	**Beispiele und Belege**
For example / **For instance**, …	Zum Beispiel …
A good example of this is …	Ein gutes Beispiel dafür ist …
This can be seen in …	Dies zeigt sich an / in …
As the author points out, "…" (l. 12).	Wie der Autor hervorhebt, „…" (Z. 12).
Conclusion – your opinion	**Schluss – eigene Meinung**
All things considered, I believe that …	Alles in allem glaube ich, dass …
Weighing up both sides, I am convinced that …	Wenn ich beide Seiten abwäge, bin ich überzeugt, dass …
To sum up, the arguments in favour of … **outweigh those against it.**	Zusammenfassend überwiegen die Argumente für … die Argumente dagegen.
In my view / **To my mind**, …	Meiner Ansicht nach …
Coming back to the quotation / statement, …	Um auf das Zitat / die Aussage zurückzukommen, …

AVOID

× *In my opinion I think …*	× *Everybody knows that …*	× *I* before the conclusion
✓ *In my opinion, …*	✓ *It is often argued that …*	✓ *I* only in the conclusion

Model essay

The model task from page 1, written out. TS thesis statement D development E example **bold** = phrases from page 2

Introduction
starting point → question

"Nobody has the right to not be offended." With these words, the novelist Salman Rushdie defended freedom of speech: in a free society, people have to accept that some ideas may shock or even hurt them. **Taking up this idea, one may ask whether** the same principle should apply to the classroom. **This raises the question of whether** students should have the right to opt out of reading disturbing fiction at school.

① – Against
my opinion · stronger

TS **Supporters of** such a right **argue that** it protects students' well-being. D Fiction can be very powerful, and scenes of violence or death may reopen painful experiences that some students have had in their own lives. Being made to read and discuss such scenes in front of the whole class can leave them feeling exposed and helpless. E **For example**, a student who has experienced domestic violence may be asked to analyse a scene in which a father beats his child, perhaps even to read it aloud in front of classmates who know nothing about his or her past.

② – Against
my opinion · weaker

TS **Another point that is often made is that** older students are mature enough to decide for themselves which texts are compatible with their own values. D Many of them are already of age, and their personal, moral or religious convictions deserve respect. Forcing them to read texts that contradict these convictions could be seen as ignoring their autonomy. E **For instance**, a student whose religious beliefs forbid explicit depictions of sex or violence may feel that reading such scenes violates his or her values.

③ + For
my opinion · weaker

TS **However, there are also convincing reasons for** keeping disturbing novels on the reading list for everyone, as shared reading depends on the whole class taking part. D Discussions about literature thrive on different perspectives. If some students opt out, these perspectives are lost, and the class can no longer explore a text together. E **A good example of this is** a debate on Harper Lee's *To Kill a Mockingbird*: without the students who skipped the novel, important views on racism and justice would be missing.

④ + For
my opinion · stronger

TS **Most importantly**, reading disturbing fiction helps young people to grow as individuals. D Literature allows readers to experience situations they would never want to face in real life, such as violence, injustice or loss. At school, students do not face these topics alone: they can share their reactions with their classmates and a teacher who guides the discussion. E **For example**, in Angie Thomas's novel *The Hate U Give*, a teenage girl witnesses the shooting of her friend by a police officer. Many readers find this scene deeply upsetting, yet it is exactly this experience that helps them understand the fear and anger of those affected by racism.

Conclusion
opinion · weighing up · back to the start

All things considered, I believe that students should not have a general right to opt out of reading disturbing fiction. **It cannot be denied that** some texts may hurt individual students. **Nevertheless**, discussing difficult topics in a guided setting helps students to grow and makes class discussions richer. **Coming back to** Rushdie's statement, I would argue that being disturbed by a novel is not a reason to avoid it but a chance to learn.